

Terms of Use (“Terms of Use”) Catalyst App (Prototype/Beta)

These Terms of Use govern the use of the “Catalyst” app/platform (the “App”). Please read these terms carefully. By registering and/or using the App, you accept these Terms of Use.

I. Scope, purpose and non-commercial use

1. These Terms of Use apply to all users of the Catalyst App.
2. The purpose of the App is to support scientific exchange by suggesting potential “matches” between researchers (scientist matchmaking).
3. The App is operated in an academic context and is not intended to generate profit (non-commercial).

II. Provider / Responsible entity

1. The provider of the App is the **Max Planck Society for the Advancement of Science (MPG)**, represented by the **Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems (MPI-IS)** (the “Provider”).
Address: Heisenbergstr. 3, 70569 Stuttgart Germany
Contact: rumley@is.mpg.de
Project lead/contact person: Ellen Rumley
The Provider may in future cooperate with research partners (currently, potentially, the University of Tübingen). Any cooperation that is relevant to data protection or the use of the App will be communicated transparently.

III. Eligibility and registration

1. The target group is scientists/researchers at research institutions.
2. Use is permitted only for persons aged **18 or over**.
3. Participation is voluntary. There is no entitlement to use or to permanent operation of the App.
4. The Provider may restrict use during a test phase to specific groups (e.g. MPG-affiliated researchers and, where applicable, the University of Tübingen). Any such restrictions will be displayed in advance in the App or during registration.
5. Registration is required to use the App. Users must provide truthful information when registering and must keep their access credentials confidential.

IV. Description of services (core functionalities)

1. After registration, the App creates a profile and, at regular intervals (e.g. weekly), displays suggestions for potentially relevant contacts (“matches”).
2. Users can rate matches (e.g. “no interest”, “already know”, “interested”, “show later”).
3. User profiles may include, inter alia, the following information:
 - Name
 - institutional affiliation
 - institutional email address
 - research keywords / abstract / description of research interests
 - optional photo
 - career stage
4. Profiles may be enriched with external scholarly metadata (e.g. via the OpenAlex API) in order to improve match suggestions.

V. Beta/prototype status, further development and limitations

1. The App is in a prototype/beta phase. Features, matching logic, data collection and presentation may change.
2. Errors, interruptions, loss of data, or incomplete/inaccurate suggestions may occur. No particular outcome (e.g. collaborations actually being established) is owed.
3. For prototype testing purposes, artificially created test profiles (“mock users”) may appear in suggestions. Such profiles will be identified as artificial/created for testing purposes (at the latest retrospectively).

VI. Scientific use / evaluation

1. The App serves scientific objectives, including improving matching between scientists and understanding (aggregated) patterns of exchange and interests across scientific disciplines.
2. Data will be used for scientific analyses only within the scope of the purposes, legal bases and safeguards described in the privacy policy (e.g. aggregation/anonymisation or pseudonymisation).
3. Any publications—if any—will be in a form that does not allow conclusions to be drawn about individual persons, unless expressly stated otherwise in the privacy policy.

VII. Users’ obligations

1. The App may be used only within the intended scientific context.
2. In particular, the following is prohibited:
 - misuse (e.g. spam, harassment, “scraping”, unauthorised bulk downloads),
 - legal violations, in particular of data protection, copyright or personal rights,
 - disruption or manipulation of the App, circumvention of security mechanisms.
3. Users must not upload/provide any content for which they do not hold the necessary rights (e.g. photos, texts).
4. Access credentials must not be shared with third parties.

VIII. Rights in content and rights of use

1. Users generally retain rights in their own profile content (e.g. self-written texts, uploaded photos), but grant the Provider a simple, non-exclusive, non-transferable licence to the extent necessary for operating, displaying and further developing the App.
2. The App, its software, interface, marks/designations and other components are protected by copyright and/or other intellectual property rights in favour of the Provider or third parties.
3. Users are granted a simple, revocable, non-transferable right to use the App for their own non-commercial, science-related purposes within the scope of these Terms of Use.
4. Reverse engineering, decompilation or unauthorised reproduction/distribution is prohibited to the extent not permitted by law.

IX. Open source and third-party components

1. The source code of the App is intended to be published (in whole or in part) as open source. Where open-source licences apply, they take precedence for the relevant components. Details will be documented in the repository/in the App.

2. Third-party services (e.g. OpenAlex, HuggingFace, Novita AI) may be integrated; their terms of use and availability are outside the Provider's control. These can be viewed at:
https://openalex.org/OpenAlex_termsofservice.pdf,
<https://novita.ai/legal/terms-of-service>,
<https://huggingface.co/terms-of-service>.

X. Data protection

1. Information on the processing of personal data is set out in the privacy policy, which forms part of the user relationship.
2. As the App is under development, the privacy policy may be updated. Users will be informed transparently about material changes. Where required, renewed consent may be obtained for new purposes of processing.

XI. Availability, support and changes to the service

1. The Provider does not owe any specific availability, any specific features, or any support.
2. The Provider may adapt, extend, restrict or discontinue features, in particular as part of prototype development.

XII. Liability

1. The Provider is liable in accordance with statutory provisions in cases of intent and gross negligence.
2. In cases of simple negligence, the Provider is liable only for breach of essential contractual obligations (cardinal obligations) and is then limited to the damage typically foreseeable.
3. Liability for the accuracy, completeness or scientific usefulness of match suggestions is excluded.

XIII. Term, termination and discontinuation of the project

1. The user relationship runs for an indefinite period for as long as the App is operated or until the user deletes their profile.
2. Users may terminate their use at any time (e.g. by deleting the account, where offered, or by notifying support). Details on deletion/retention follow from the privacy policy.
3. The prototype operation is currently planned for a maximum of one year; long-term maintenance is intended but not guaranteed.
4. If the project is discontinued, the App may no longer be maintained. The handling of data after the end of the project is governed by the privacy policy and the purposes and retention/deletion rules stated therein.

XIV. Suspension / exclusion

The Provider may temporarily or permanently suspend user accounts if there are indications of misuse, legal violations or risks to operation/security interests. The Provider will observe the principle of proportionality; prior notice will be given where appropriate.

XV. Changes to these Terms of Use

1. The Provider may amend these Terms of Use, in particular as part of further development of the App or due to changes in the law.

2. Users will be informed in good time about material changes. Unless stated otherwise, continued use after notification constitutes acceptance of the amended Terms of Use.

XVI. Ethics / sensitive areas

1. No ethics approval/opinion is currently in place for the App, and no ethics application is currently planned.
2. The App is not designed to process health data or similarly sensitive categories. Research interests and preferences are processed in an academic context.

XVII. Applicable law

German law applies, excluding the UN Convention on Contracts for the International Sale of Goods (CISG).